Slow Dance on the Killing Ground
by William Hanley

RANDALL: Hey daddy! Didn't see you up there! Pretty neat, yes indeedy!

MR. GLAS: What can I do for you?

RANDALL: I mean, what can you do for me. The possibilities are endless, know what I mean? Right? But we start with somethin' easy. Gimme a . . . gimme an egg cream. You of European abstraction. . .

MR. GLAS: I beg your pardon?

RANDALL: Your accent. Originally you speak another tongue, I mean you come from across the sea, right?

MR. GLAS: Oh, ***Ex***-traction

RANDALL: *(Turns to Glas)* Sir?

MR. GLAS: You said abstraction. The word is extraction. European extraction.

RANDALL: Oh, Yeah. . . well, I stand corrected, daddy.

MR. GLAS: I don't see you around here before, sonny.

RANDALL: Do me a little favor; don't call me sonny

MR. GLAS: What's your name?

RANDALL: Randall. What's yours?

MR. GLAS: Glas.

INTRODUCTION

Meet Randall, a young black man on the run from the reality of his own creation. And Mr. Glas, struggling to deal with an impossible choice made decades ago. Both dance around reality . . . Always on guard . . . afraid to face their personal truths, let alone share them with others. They hide behind the images they have chosen to show to the world. This night, however, a chance meeting between strangers offers a safe haven for the unburdening of two troubled souls. The music has begun . . . it is time for this

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RANDALL: What kinda name is that, Glas?

MR. GLAS: German for the Glas with two esses.

RANDALL: Oh, I dig. German. I like that. Glas with one s. And now that my attention been called to it, and you don't mind me sayin', but the glass with two esses here could use a little washin', I do believe. You can's hardly even see through it. It donwnright dirty, that glass with two esses.

MR. GLAS: There's nothing out there I particularly want to see.

RANDALL: You don't like the nature of things out there particularly?

MR. GLAS: Exactly.

RANDALL: Well now, you see? I had a feelin', I just ***knew*** we was brothers under the skin, somehow. I hasten to repeat, under the skin, no offense intended, no indeed, sir. But I know exactly what you mean, exactly! I mean, it is grotesque out there, ain't it, now? It is . . . bizarre! You know what it is out there, daddy? You know? That is ***killing*** ground out there. I mean that's No Mans Land out there, daddy! That somebody ***else's*** turf, a regular mine field, you gotta step carefully, they *kill* you out there, know what I mean?

MR. GLAS: Not exactly

RANDALL: Butcher shop. It a regular butcher shop out there. You know what happened out there just last year alone? What happened out the- and I quote – what happened out there was four hundred and eighty three homicides! "Contrary to public impression, most homicides are spontaneous and are committed in the home; they are not the result of gangland reprisals but of family disputes. Oh, man, man… (picks up newspaper and looks at is, reading an article.. meanwhile Glas is just staring at Randal, perplexed.) O see where they really hung his ass, hah? This here Nazi cat, I mean. Them Jews really hung his ass, after all.

MR. GLAS: Yeah, sure.

RANDALL: I do perceive you ain't got much sympathy for some of the various and sundry dilemmas currently facin' mankind, then?

MR. GLAS: No. . . What are you running away from? When you came in here: what were you running away from?

RANDALL: Where'd you get an idea like that, baby? Where in the world?

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MR. GLAS: You got trouble out there, don't bring it in here.

RANDALL: What'd you have in mind I was runnin' away from?

MR. GLAS: How would I know?

RANDALL: True, 'course there's a lotta possibilities. Lemme see, now. . . could be I knocked over my friendly neighborhood grocery store to get me an apple and a little loose change?. . . Or perhaps I am a remnant of one of our local altercations commonly known as the gang rumble, in which several children have been slain, slain on the field of battle?. . . That don't appeal to you neither? Well, lemmee see, now… could be I just recently committed a criminal assault on a white lady of middle age in the dark deserted end of a subway station platform?. . . No? Or perhaps, perhaps – this a good one – perhaps I just up and done away with my momma, stabbin' her numerous times about the breast and abdomen with an ice pick.

MR. GLAS: What were you running away from?

RANDALL: You the persistent type though, ain't you daddy. Ain't always a good idea to be too persistent, though, you know?. . . I mean, … What is Truth, said Jesting Pilate and would not stay for an answer. You know who said that? You know? Francis Bacon was the one who said it.

MR. GLAS: I don't like that kinda talk!

RANDALL: What kinda talk is that, daddy?

MR. GLAS: And stop calling me Daddy!

RANDALL: No offense intended, sir, I assure you. It is definitely not my intention to impugn the purity of you ancestral heritage, seein' as how I heard that a lotta you German folks was unusually sensitive to that topic at one time in the not-to-distant past. Course, you bein' a Jew and all…

MR. GLAS: I'm not a Jew

RANDALL: Here I been goin' on the false assumption that you was. Is. A Jewish man. That bein' the case, it been hard for me to reconcile the fact that you ain't been givin' a shit one way or the other about old Aldolf here, swayin' gently to and fro, as they say, with a broken

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neck, ruptured larynx, deceased. But you not bein' a Jew, I now comprehend totally. Your indifference.

MR. GLAS: You think only Jews care?

RANDALL: They do seem to be the ones most upset and distraught by the matter, yeah. I mean they 'as the ones who ***hung*** him. Seem to me somewhat bloodthirsty.

MR. GLAS: What do ***you*** know about it?

RANDALL: What I read in the newspapers, baby.

MR. GLAS: There's more to know than you read in the newspapers, believe me.

RANDALL: What do you know about it?

MR. GLAS: ***I know! I know!***

RANDALL: Of course you do, I know that. But what exactly? Your turn to speak, Mister Glas…

MR. GLAS: This man . . . do you know what they say? They say that when they arrested his he appeared to be relieved. Not frightened. Not defiant. They say he appeared to be – ***relieved***!. . . Do you know why? I'll tell you why. Because all these years he knew, you see. He waited, and he knew that sooner or later it would happed: the discovery that would mean his judgment and his death. And the anticipation pf a blow is always, somehow, more terrible than the blow itself when it finally comes. So one can understand his relief. When the blow finally came. But I had a wife who was a Jew. And a son who was a Jew. Nineteen thirty eight, a man might as well have been a Jew himself: the Nazis made no distinctions. And, of course, to have been a Jew then was to wait for the day they opened your door and took you away. They opened so many doors… so many doors… and came out with Jews in their fists… Most men, you know, most men can live all of their lives with the conviction that they have honor, and they can go to their graves with that conviction without ever having been put to the test of it. I envy them, the ones who escape the test. Not me. In the summer of nineteen thirty eight I had my test, my choice to make: to wait until I was taken to a concentration camp as a Jew with my Jewish wife and my Jewish son… or to live as a Communist and fight for my country, my Germany, against the Nazis. And, to save my life for that fight, I abandoned them, my wife and my child, in the middle of the night without a word. I went to another city, I took another name. For nearly a year I carried freight

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between Hamburg and Cologne: chemicals, machinery, armaments. And then I was transferred to another run, to a place called Mauthausen, and the freight was people. … Three trips I made in two months and I carried hundreds and hundreds of people, of Jews, to the concentration camp at Mauthausen… Until August, nineteen thirty nine, and Stalin made his pact with Hitler. Communism embraced Nazism, my god kissed Satan and called him friend. In that moment there was a new truth: that I had abandoned my wife and son to the wolves and saved myself for nothing. For *nothing*! And I went back . . . and in the house the windows were smashed. . . and the door was open. . . and they were gone. I left Germany them. . . I know. . . For this man. . . the waiting is over. He committed a crime for which a punishment has been named, you see. But me. Who will judge me? Who will condemn ***me,*** and by what law?

RANDALL: You stand accused, Mister Glas, sir!

MR. GLAS: *What, what!?!*

RANDALL: Accused, yes, of continuing to live. . . Hear ye! Hear ye! God bless all here! We are gathered together here for certain special and particular purposes, to wit: to determine the guilt or innocence of one, Glas, first name unknown and immaterial, brought forward here and now before this here qualified tri-bunal with the view in mind to settin' his heretofore troubled conscience at rest concernin' a certain matter, to wit: his need to be judged. How do you plead? Guilty or not guilty?

MR. GLAS: Guilty

RANDALL: Done, then. *(takes a gun from his coat, puts it to Glas's temple and pulls the trigger)*

MR. GLAS: It should have been loaded, hah?

RANDALL: No sword of justice will pierce ***your*** heart, Mister Glas *(pause)* Glas, if I were dying right now, would you save my life?

MR. GLAS: I don't know. Maybe, if I could. Why?

RANDALL: Would you die for me? Would you go that far?

MR. GLAS: No. There is only one Jesus Christ, sonny. *(pause)* Randall? What have you done? Tell me Randall. It's time. You owe it to me Randall.

RANDALL: Do I. Yes I suppose I do, all things considered, mm, hm *(long pause)*

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MR. GLAS: Go on, Randall.

RANDALL: Up the stairs, first. One flight, two flights, three flights, four. Through the door. Into the room. Dark. Sit. Wait. Noises in the bedroom, familiar noises in the bedroom. Creak, moan. Creak, moan. Creak, moan. Momma moaning, giving value for money. Wait. Quiet. Dark. Clock, tickticktick, clock, tickticktick. Fire engine. Clock, tickticktick. He comes out of the bedroom, head down, faceless man, buttoning, shoelaces clicking on the linoleum. Out the door. Slam. Quiet. Wait. Bedspring creaks. Match strikes in the bedroom. Exhalation. Don't smoke in the bed, momma: everybody says. Randall stands up. Into the bedroom. Mama on the bed, black on white. Screams. Covers up. No words. Screams when the knife comes down. Screams when the knife comes down. Screams when the knife goes down. Many times. Knife breaks. Ice-pick. Small round holes in the white sheet pumping blood. No screams no more . . . no momma no more, no momma no more!

MR. GLAS: They'll catch you, Randall, they'll kill you. I can't save you. A little bit, maybe. But finally – no.

RANDALL: Why don't you see. . . I must die, in violence, because of what I am and because of what I have done. Just as you must live, without violence, because of what you are and what you have done. . . We choose the dark streets up which we walk. We choose them. And if we are guilty of the denial of life, who is there to save us from that. . . but ourselves?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: William Hanley
ISBN: 978-0822210436
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc
Date: Jan 1998

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